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Philosophy of Politics:

The beginnings of the modern state and political ideologies

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The Beginnings of the Modern State and Political Ideologies

- From medieval political order to the sovereign state
- From subjects to citizens
- From dynastic legitimacy to popular and national legitimacy
- From political philosophy to modern political ideology
- Central question: What changed when the state became “modern”?

The Problem of the Modern State

- The state is not simply another word for government
- Governments change; the state claims institutional continuity
- The modern state claims supreme authority over a defined territory
- It increasingly governs individuals directly rather than through intermediate authorities
- It develops permanent institutions of administration, taxation, law and military power
- Modern ideologies offer competing answers to the question: what should this state be for?

Before the Modern State

- Medieval Europe did not consist of sovereign territorial states in the modern sense
- Political authority was overlapping and divided
- Kings and princes
- Feudal lords
- Cities and communes
- Estates and corporations
- Church and papacy
- Holy Roman Empire
- There was no simple equation: one territory = one sovereign = one law

Medieval Political Community

- A person could simultaneously be subject to several forms of authority
- Political membership was differentiated by estate, status and privilege
- Rights were often attached to groups rather than possessed equally by individuals
- Society was commonly conceived as an ordered hierarchy
- Political equality was not the organizing principle
- Authority was attached to persons, privileges and jurisdictions as much as to territory

The Transformation

- Between roughly the sixteenth and nineteenth centuries, European political organization underwent a long transformation
- Political authority became increasingly centralized
- Territorial boundaries became more important
- Administrative institutions expanded
- Taxation became more systematic
- Permanent military organizations developed
- Legal authority became increasingly standardized
- Rulers sought more direct authority over populations

War and State Formation

- Warfare became increasingly expensive
- Armies required taxation
- Taxation required administration
- Administration required records and officials
- Officials required centralized authority
- Centralized authority increased the state's capacity to wage war
- State formation was simultaneously military, fiscal, administrative and political

The State as an Institution

- The ruler and the political order gradually become conceptually separable
- The king is a person
- The crown is an office
- The government is an organization
- The state is an enduring political entity
- Political authority survives individual rulers
- This institutional continuity is fundamental to the modern state

Machiavelli and the Autonomy of Politics

- Niccolò Machiavelli, 1469–1527
- Politics analyzed as a distinctive sphere of human activity
- Political success cannot simply be reduced to Christian morality
- Attention to power, institutions, conflict and military organization
- Central questions:
 - How is political power acquired?
 - How is it maintained?
 - Why do states collapse?
- Political necessity becomes a central category

Jean Bodin and Sovereignty

- Jean Bodin, 1530–1596
- *Six Books of the Commonwealth*, 1576
- Context: French Wars of Religion
- Political fragmentation creates the problem of final authority
- Who has the last word?
- Bodin's answer: sovereignty
- Sovereignty becomes a foundational concept of modern political thought

What Is Sovereignty?

- Sovereignty means supreme political authority
- There cannot be two equally supreme authorities within the same political order
- It establishes a hierarchy of political command
- Three fundamental questions:
 - Over whom is sovereignty exercised?
 - What limits, if any, bind the sovereign?
- These questions will recur throughout the course

Hobbes and the Problem of Political Order

- Thomas Hobbes, 1588–1679
- *Leviathan*, 1651
- English Civil War as crucial context
- Hobbes begins from individuals rather than naturally given political hierarchy
- Political authority must therefore be explained
- Why should one person obey another?
- Security becomes the fundamental political problem

Hobbes: State of Nature and Social Contract

- Without common authority, individuals confront insecurity
- Scarcity, distrust and competition generate conflict
- Agreements are unstable without enforcement
- Political order requires a power capable of enforcing rules
- Individuals authorize sovereign authority
- Political order becomes an artificial human construction
- Authority is justified through the needs and actions of individuals

The Paradox of Hobbes

- Hobbes begins with individuals
- But arrives at an extremely powerful sovereign
- Individualism does not necessarily imply a weak state
- The modern state can simultaneously be:
 - constructed from individuals
 - justified for individuals
 - enormously powerful over individuals
- This tension will reappear throughout modern political thought

Westphalia and the Territorial State

- Peace of Westphalia, 1648
- Conventionally associated with the development of sovereign states
- Territorial political authority becomes increasingly important
- But the modern state did not suddenly appear in 1648
- State formation was a long process before and after Westphalia
- “Westphalia” is better understood as a landmark than as the single birth date of the modern state

The Emerging Territorial State

- Increasingly defined territory and borders
- Centralized administration
- Regular taxation
- Standing military forces
- Permanent diplomatic relations
- Increasingly uniform legal authority
- More direct relationship between state institutions and inhabitants
- The state becomes an increasingly impersonal apparatus of rule

Absolutism and Centralization

- Seventeenth and eighteenth-century state-building was frequently associated with monarchy
- Reduction of competing feudal and corporate powers
- Expansion of royal administration
- Expansion of taxation and military capacity
- France under Louis XIV provides an important example
- But absolutism never meant unlimited practical control
- Privileges, customs, institutions and material limitations remained

The State Before Democracy

- Centralized states develop before mass democracy
- Bureaucracy develops before universal suffrage
- Standing armies develop before democratic citizenship
- Taxation develops before equal political rights
- Modern democracy therefore inherits an already powerful machinery of state
- The later question becomes: who should control it, and for what purposes?

Locke: Limited Government

- John Locke, 1632–1704
- *Second Treatise of Government*, 1689
- Individuals possess rights prior to government
- Life, liberty and property
- Government exists to protect rights
- Political authority is limited by its purpose
- Government exercises a trust
- Systematic violation of that trust can justify resistance

Hobbes and Locke

- Hobbes:
 - insecurity is the fundamental problem
 - strong sovereign authority provides peace
- Locke:
 - arbitrary authority is itself a fundamental problem
 - government must be limited by rights
- Both begin from individuals
- Both explain rather than merely assume political authority
- They produce very different accounts of legitimate government

Enlightenment and the Critique of Authority

- Inherited authority is increasingly subjected to rational criticism
- Why monarchy?
- Why aristocratic privilege?
- Why established religious authority?
- Why unequal political status?
- Why censorship?
- Political institutions increasingly require justification
- Tradition alone becomes a less sufficient answer

The Revolutionary Transformation

- American Revolution, 1776
- French Revolution, 1789
- Political theory becomes revolutionary practice
- Constitutions can be deliberately created
- Governments can be reconstructed
- Sovereignty can be attributed to “the people”
- Political membership can be reformulated as citizenship
- Rights and popular sovereignty become institutional projects

From Subject to Citizen

- The French Revolution attacks the political structure of the Old Regime
- Privilege is challenged
- Estates are challenged
- Dynastic legitimacy is challenged
- Citizenship becomes a central political category
- Equality before law becomes a revolutionary principle
- The political community is increasingly imagined as a nation of citizens

Popular Sovereignty and Its Problems

- If kings are not sovereign by divine or hereditary right, who is?
- Revolutionary answer: the people
- But who constitutes “the people”?
- How can millions exercise a single sovereign will?
- Can representatives speak for the people?
- Can a majority oppress a minority?
- Can political leaders claim to know the people's “true” interests better than the people themselves?
- Popular sovereignty changes rather than eliminates the problem of sovereignty

State, Nation and Nationalism

- State = political and institutional organization
- Nation = political or cultural community
- A state may contain several national identities
- A nation may exist without its own state
- Nineteenth-century nationalism increasingly demands correspondence between nation and political authority
- Education, administration and military service can strengthen national integration
- Political legitimacy increasingly invokes the nation

The New Political Questions

- Who constitutes the people?
- Who represents them?
- What rights do individuals possess?
- What should the state do?
- How should property be organized?
- What constitutes political freedom?
- What forms of inequality are legitimate?
- These questions become the terrain of modern ideological conflict

What is an Ideology?

- A structured set of political concepts, values and assumptions
- An interpretation of existing society
- An account of political legitimacy
- A conception of human beings and political community
- Identification of fundamental political problems
- An account of desirable political order
- Often a program for political action
- Ideology is therefore more than propaganda

How to Analyze an Ideology

- What is the basic political unit?
- What is the fundamental political problem?
- What makes authority legitimate?
- What does freedom mean?
- What kind of equality matters?
- What is the proper relationship between individual and community?
- What should the state do?
- We will apply these questions throughout the course

Why Modern Ideologies Emerge

- Revolutionary destruction of inherited legitimacy
- Industrialization
- Capitalism
- Urbanization
- Mass literacy
- New social classes
- Expanding political participation
- Increasing state capacity
- Politics increasingly concerns competing visions of society as a whole

The Nineteenth-Century Ideological Landscape

- Liberalism
- Conservatism
- Nationalism
- Socialism
- Communism
- Anarchism
- Republicanism
- These traditions overlap, divide and develop historically
- They offer competing answers to the problems created by political and economic modernity

Liberalism and Conservatism

- Liberalism:
 - individual liberty and rights
 - rule of law
 - constitutional restraints
 - government requires justification
- Conservatism:
 - historical continuity
 - authority
 - inherited institutions
 - skepticism toward abstract political reconstruction
- The French Revolution becomes a major dividing point between competing conceptions of political change

Socialism and the Social Question

- Legal equality does not eliminate economic inequality
- Industrial capitalism produces enormous wealth alongside poverty
- Wage labor becomes politically significant
- Property becomes a central ideological problem
- Is formal liberty sufficient without material independence?
- Socialists develop competing proposals for reorganizing economic and social relations

Marx and 1848

- Marx places class and relations of production at the center of political analysis
- Political institutions cannot be understood independently of economic relations
- Capitalism becomes an historical system rather than a permanent order
- 1848 brings liberalism, nationalism, republicanism, democracy and socialism into revolutionary conflict
- Conflicts among opponents of the Old Regime become increasingly visible
- The “social question” becomes inseparable from political theory

The Rise of Mass Politics

- Suffrage gradually expands
- Political parties develop
- Labor organizations grow
- National movements mobilize populations
- Public education expands
- Newspapers and mass communication transform political participation
- Politics increasingly concerns mobilization of large populations rather than competition among narrow elites

The Modern State Becomes a Mass State

- Bureaucracy
- Police
- Public education
- Conscription
- Census and statistics
- Public health
- Infrastructure
- Social policy
- The state increasingly seeks not merely to rule territory but to know, categorize and administer populations

Knowledge, Technology and Administration

- Modern government increasingly depends upon information
- Census
- Statistics
- Economic measurement
- Population records
- Administrative classifications
- Communication networks
- Knowledge becomes an instrument of government
- Question: can society itself become an object of rational administration?
- This problem will return in our discussion of Soviet cybernetics and Gerovitch

World War I and the Mobilized State

- 1914–1918 dramatically expands state intervention
- Mass conscription
- Economic coordination
- Rationing
- Propaganda and censorship
- Industrial mobilization
- Entire societies become objects of political organization
- War demonstrates the extraordinary mobilizing capacities of the modern state
- The postwar ideological crisis develops within this transformed political environment

Revolution, Fascism and Nazism

- 1917: communist revolution transforms socialist theory into a problem of state construction
- Fascism emerges after World War I amid nationalism, social conflict, fear of revolution and dissatisfaction with parliamentary politics
- Nazism shares important features with broader fascist movements but gives racial ideology and antisemitism a particularly constitutive role
- Twentieth-century ideological conflicts therefore concern not merely who governs
- They concern the nature and purpose of the political community itself

State, Regime, Government, Nation, Ideology

- State:
 - enduring institutions of political authority
- Regime:
 - rules determining who governs and how authority is organized
- Government:
 - persons currently exercising governing authority
- Nation:
 - political/cultural community claiming collective identity
- Ideology:
 - framework through which political order is interpreted and justified
- These concepts must not be used interchangeably

Conceptual Architecture of the Course

- Nazism
 - existential and racialized politics
 - membership, enemy, race and sovereignty
- Fascism
 - ethical-organic state
 - political unity, hierarchy and the relationship between individual and state
- Communism
 - class, historical transformation and rational organization
 - exploitation, revolution and post-capitalist social organization
- Liberalism
 - individual liberty and pluralism
 - reconciling freedom with political authority
- Libertarianism
 - self-ownership and limited government
 - legitimate limits of state coercion

Questions to Carry Through the Course

- Who has final political authority?
- What makes authority legitimate?
- What does it mean to be free?
- In what respects should human beings be equal?
- Who constitutes the political “we”?
- What may individuals legitimately own?
- Is political conflict avoidable or constitutive of politics?
- Can society be deliberately designed?
- Who possesses the knowledge necessary to govern?
- How much power should the modern state possess?